History

Submitted for the April, 2026 Conference on 02/26/2026

Research Details

“Because We Shared Topaz”: Shared Identity and Interracial Memory of an Internment Camp School

This study applies Brubaker’s (2006) concept of “groupness” to examine how shared experiences, rather than racial categorization, enabled belonging among students at Topaz High School, which operated within the Central Utah War Relocation Center and was attended primarily by Japanese American incarcerees. Drawing on oral histories, correspondence records, and other archival materials, this research found that students at an internment camp high school developed a sense of identity and community (groupness) that transcended racial categorizations. In addition, the study found that historical memory preserves groupness over time as white students are included in the process of collective memory.

Submission Details

Presenters Jamie Hernandez, River Blake

Mentors Dr. Vivian Holloway

Department History

Degree Undergraduate

Additional Awards Redd Center, Belonging, Becoming, Center for Family History and Genealogy

Additional Awards

Award	Reason
Belonging and Diversity	Study purpose is related to under-represented groups and the data focuses on or is collected from under-represented groups. *Please state how your research relates to these requirements.* **I want to apply for the Belonging and Diversity Additional Award because I value creating environments where people from different backgrounds feel respected, included, and supported. Through service, leadership, and everyday interactions, I strive to build understanding, strengthen community connections, and help**

Poster

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Co-presenters

Kate Mayers - katemtate

Janet Moore - janetm63

Add Mentors

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Mentors

John David - History

Alice James - History